Rehearse a Care Review for Your Mother Before Any Care Begins

Four prompts to decide what a future review would compare, try it on a made-up week, work out who could gather what, and list the access questions to ask any provider later.

Where you are

Your mother lives on her own and is doing well. You've started talking as a family about what help might look like someday, and you've realized none of you would know how to tell whether a care plan was being followed. There's no rush, which is exactly why this is a good time.

This guide gives you four ChatGPT prompts to organize what you already know and to see what you don't know yet. It is preparation, not an assessment. Use only information you have permission to share, with names removed. The AI organizes and drafts; it does not diagnose, assess safety, or decide. Bring clinical questions to a clinician, and call emergency services for an emergency.

What you'll have at the end

You have a practice review template your family has tried once on a fictional scenario, with names beside the jobs and a clear list of what you'd need to ask a provider for.

A one-page practice review template with headings What we'd compare, Who could gather it, How we'll keep unknowns visible, and Questions for a future provider.

Before you start

- A rough idea of the kinds of help your mother might one day need, even if it's a guess.
- The names of relatives and friends who might be willing to visit, call, or keep notes.
- Any experience a family member has had with a care setting, good or bad. If you have none of this, that's fine; the prompts work from a made-up example.

PROMPT 1

Decide what a review would actually compare

WHY THIS MATTERS

A review compares what was agreed with what happened. Families who skip the first half end up with a notebook of visits and nothing to hold them against. Agreeing what you'd compare is the whole foundation.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Your rough guess at the kinds of help your mother might someday have.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> My mother is well right now, but we want to practice reviewing care before we need to. Here are the kinds of help I imagine she might one day have:

> [LIST THE KINDS OF HELP YOU IMAGINE, HOWEVER ROUGH]
>
> For each one, write what an agreed expectation might look like in a care plan, in one plain sentence, and then what a family member could actually observe about it on a visit. Keep the two in separate columns labeled EXPECTATION and WHAT WE COULD SEE. Put PRACTICE EXAMPLE, NOT A REAL PLAN at the top. Do not suggest how much help she needs or which kinds are likely.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

Expectations too vague to observe, which is the first thing you'd want fixed in a real plan.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Rewrite the vaguest expectation until a stranger could check it on a single visit.

PROMPT 2

Try the review on a made-up week

WHY THIS MATTERS

You learn what a review feels like by filling one in, not by reading about it. A fictional week with gaps in it shows the family how much stays unknown even when everyone is paying attention.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

The two columns from Prompt 1.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> Here is our practice list of care expectations and what we could observe:
>
> [PASTE PROMPT 1]
>
> Invent a plausible week of care for a fictional person, with two visits by relatives and one phone call, and write five or six short dated observations from it. Then show how those observations would fill a review with columns: expectation, observation or report, source and date, and status (SEEN, REPORTED TO US, or UNKNOWN). Leave at least half the items UNKNOWN so we see what a real review looks like with missing information. Mark the whole thing clearly as fictional.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

How much stays UNKNOWN even in a tidy invented week. That's normal, and it's what the review is for.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Show the fictional review to one relative and ask whether they'd know how to fill in a row.

PROMPT 3

Work out who could gather what

WHY THIS MATTERS

Review work tends to fall on whoever lives closest, and it stays there until that person burns out. Listing the jobs separately from the people lets the family see the load before anyone is carrying it.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Names of possible helpers with where they live, their schedules, and what they're comfortable doing.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> These are the people who might help keep an eye on my mother's care someday, with where they live, their schedules, and what they're comfortable doing:
>
> [PASTE NAMES, LOCATIONS, SCHEDULES, COMFORT LEVELS]
>
> Make a table of possible review jobs: visiting, phoning my mother, talking with staff or an aide, keeping the written review, and chairing a family check-in. For each job, list who could plausibly do it, how often is realistic given what I told you, and whether it currently depends on one person. Flag any job where only one name appears. Do not assign the jobs for us; give us options to discuss.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

Jobs that rest on one person, usually the one who lives closest.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Bring the table to a family call and let people volunteer rather than be assigned.

PROMPT 4

Draft the template and the provider questions

WHY THIS MATTERS

Families assume they will see the aide's notes or the residence's records. Often they won't, or not without asking. The questions about access belong on paper now, so they get asked on day one instead of month three.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

The columns, the fictional review, and the jobs table from the three prompts above.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> Here is our practice work so far on reviewing my mother's future care:
>
> [PASTE EVERYTHING FROM PROMPTS 1 TO 3]
>
> Write one page with four headings: WHAT WE'D COMPARE, WHO COULD GATHER IT, HOW WE'LL KEEP UNKNOWNS VISIBLE, and QUESTIONS FOR A FUTURE PROVIDER. Under the last heading, draft the questions we would need to ask any home care agency or residence about what information families receive, how often, through whom, and how to raise a question. Phrase them neutrally. Mark the page as a practice template with blank fields, and do not fill in any provider's answers or guess what they would say.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

A page with more blanks than answers, and a list of questions no family should have to think up on moving day.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

File it with your mother's other planning documents and put today's date on it.

Give the practice a real starting point

A review template is only as good as the picture of the person behind it. The care interview organizes your mother's current situation into a Family Care Profile, the file your family's roles and future questions can attach to as things change.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›